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▶ BIHAR

BULLETS IN BIHAR

From being a transit state for arms smuggling, Bihar is now being seen as a final destination. High incidence of violent crimes seems to be fuelling the supply

IN DECEMBER, THE NATIONAL INVESTIGATION AGENCY (NIA) raided 23 locations in Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to bust a deadly supply chain, one that diverted legally manufactured ammunition and factory-grade weapons to the grey market. The arrests, too, were spread out: Kamal Kant alias 'Uncleji', based in Auraiya, UP, and Vijay and Kush Kalra, owners of a government-recognised gun house in Kurukshetra, Haryana, from whom he sourced ammunition. But there was a ballistic trajectory in plain sight: all the bullets were flying to Bihar.

The searches yielded Rs 1 crore in cash, besides a digital and documentary cache, including the usual forged IDs. "The money flow and communication data pointed to sustained arms trafficking," says an officer of Bihar Police's Special Task Force (STF). Two Patna residents, Ravi Ranjan and Shashi Prakash, landed in the slammer after interrogations outed their names.

It all started in late June 2025, when the STF intercepted a Maruti Brezza at Mohania toll plaza in Kaimur district on a tip: flaps fitted above the wheel arches hid 3,700 live cartridges. Subsequent raids, including in Nalanda, yielded another 800-odd rounds.

That forced a relook at a long-held assumption about the state's role in the illegal arms economy. For decades, Bihar had been seen either as a legacy source of crude, country-made weapons or as a transit corridor for arms. Now, it seemed Bihar had become a destina-